

NATIONAL GRAND LODGE OF GREECE

GRAND MASTER

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MAKING GOOD MEN BETTER

*The Meaning, History, Discipline, and Modern Value
of Freemasonry's Best-Known Maxim*

Few short phrases attached to Freemasonry have had the staying power of “Make good men better.” It is memorable because it compresses an entire moral programme into six plain words. It does not promise wealth, power, salvation, political victory, or intellectual superiority. It promises improvement. And it assumes that the improvement worth pursuing begins not from corruption but from some prior moral capacity: a man already capable of honesty, self-command, loyalty, and responsibility enters a discipline meant to refine him further. That economy of language is part of the phrase’s power. It sounds modest, but it contains an ambitious theory of human formation.

The phrase is also powerful because it bridges eras. In eighteenth-century terms, it resonates with the language of “good and true men,” merit, civility, brotherly love, and moral instruction. In modern terms, it resonates with character development, ethical reflection, fraternity, service, and civic responsibility. The United Grand Lodge of England (UGLE) today describes Freemasonry as a structure through which members build character, develop themselves, form friendships, and contribute to society; it publicly frames Masonic life around Integrity, Friendship, Respect, and Service. That is not identical wording to the older constitutions, but it is recognisably the same family of ideas. The maxim endured because it can be re-expressed without losing its core: Freemasonry claims to take men who are already morally serious and place them in a disciplined environment where they are expected to become more thoughtful, more dependable, more charitable, and more useful.

Why the phrase became powerful

The first reason lies in its rhetorical design. Good mottos survive because they are simple enough to remember and deep enough to revisit. “Make good men better” has both features. It avoids doctrinal density and leaves room for interpretation: “good,” “better,” and “make” are all morally charged yet open terms. That allows the phrase to work for men of different professions, temperaments, generations, and national jurisdictions. A phrase that broad can travel globally. The listener hears it once and already understands the aspiration, even before learning the ritual or symbolism. The second reason is that the phrase suits Freemasonry’s method. Freemasonry has long presented itself as a moral system taught through allegory, symbol, staged progression, and shared discipline. Freemasonry explains that its degree ceremonies teach members how to be better people and represent stages in life; it also says Freemasonry uses building analogies to teach members how to lead productive lives that benefit their communities. A phrase about “making better” naturally suits a fraternity whose central metaphors involve working tools, rough stone becoming shaped stone, advancement through degrees, and merit rather than mere rank. The third reason is social rather than merely verbal. Freemasonry historically offered more than ideas: it offered a repeated setting in which ideas could be embodied. Scholarship on eighteenth-century Freemasonry has stressed that lodges were major voluntary associations in the emerging world of civil society, places where men practiced sociability, self-government, order, fraternity, and public-mindedness. Historians such as Margaret Jacob have argued that Masonic associational life helped model forms of civic behaviour and social cooperation beyond family, church, and state. A motto becomes durable when it names what members think they are actually doing together. The fourth reason is that the phrase answers a basic human anxiety: How does a man improve once he is no longer a child? Modern societies are full of technical training but poor at adult moral formation. Freemasonry’s appeal, at least in its own self-understanding, is that it gives adulthood a school of character. UGLE’s public language reflects this: members are empowered to be the best they can be, to build character, and to make better choices. That promise remains legible in a modern world precisely because adult men still want formation, not just information.

Has it remained unchanged for three centuries?

The core aspiration remained, but the language, emphasis, and social context changed a great deal. What stayed relatively constant was the conviction that Masonry is about moral improvement through disciplined fellowship. What changed was how

that conviction was articulated, what sort of man was imagined as the candidate, which virtues were stressed, and how the social value of Masonry was explained. In the early eighteenth century, the governing language was not “make good men better” in the modern publicity sense. The famous 1723 constitutional tradition and later UGLE constitutional texts speak of admitting “good and true men” and grounding preferment on “real worth and personal merit only.” Those phrases reflect an older moral grammar: honour, discretion, reputation, merit, obedience, and social trustworthiness. They also reflect a world structured by rank, patriarchy, and exclusions that modern readers cannot ignore. The phrase “good man” then did not mean simply a kind and decent person in contemporary egalitarian language; it also implied a man whose public reputation, legal status, maturity, and comportment made him fit for entry into an orderly fraternity. By contrast, modern UGLE presents Freemasonry in a more public, inclusive, and developmental register. Its membership pages state that membership is open to any man over 18 irrespective of race or religion, while its guidance materials still maintain the requirement of belief in a Supreme Being. Its public-facing language emphasises becoming thoughtful, confident, tolerant, respectful, and service-oriented. Its declared values today are Integrity, Friendship, Respect, and Service. The older ideal of moral respectability has not vanished, but it is now translated into the language of character growth, diversity, civic contribution, and transparency. So the answer is: the same centre, expressed in different language. The centre is moral formation through fraternity and symbolic discipline. The clothing has moved from eighteenth-century language of honour, discretion, and “good report” toward twenty-first-century language of values, inclusion, community engagement, and self-development.

What did it mean in the eighteenth century?

In the eighteenth century, the maxim’s closest equivalent meant at least five things. First, it meant taking men already judged respectable and placing them in a moral fraternity. The constitutional language of “good and true men” and “good report” shows that admission was tied to reputation. A lodge did not imagine itself as a prison, hospital, or revolutionary school for moral wreckage. It imagined itself as a society of men whose conduct was already sound enough that deeper trust, oath, and instruction could be built upon it. Second, it meant training men in ordered sociability.

Historians describe eighteenth-century Freemasonry as one of the largest voluntary associations of the age and a precursor to modern civil society. In that setting, “better” meant more than private virtue. It meant learning how to deliberate, behave with

decorum, manage difference, and sustain fraternity among men who might differ in class, confession, or occupation. In that respect, Masonry was not merely moralistic; it was a social means for producing trustworthy relations among non-kin. Third, it meant disciplining passions. Eighteenth-century Masonic and quasi-Masonic moral language often warned against excess, disorder, drunkenness, neglect of family, and conduct that would bring shame to the fraternity. “Better” meant more governed: more temperate, more punctual, more discreet, less ruled by appetite or vanity. That was deeply characteristic of the period’s broader moral world. Fourth, it meant advancement by merit and self-cultivation. The constitutional insistence that preferment is grounded upon “real worth and personal merit only” matters here. Freemasonry symbolically offered a counter-ideal to inherited rank: even within a hierarchical social order, it affirmed that esteem inside the lodge should depend on desert, not mere social seniority. “Better” therefore included becoming more worthy of trust and office. Fifth, it meant moral universality without sectarian collapse. Andersonian Masonry made room for men of different confessions under a generalised religious framework. UGLE’s later guidance still insists on belief in a Supreme Being while excluding theological and political debate in lodge. In eighteenth-century terms, this was significant: Masonry offered an arena where men might cooperate morally without requiring doctrinal uniformity. That helps explain why scholars treat it as important to Enlightenment sociability and civil society.

How has the meaning developed over time?

Over time, the meaning broadened from gentlemanly moral refinement to organised personal development plus public service. In the eighteenth century, the ideal candidate was often imagined through the vocabulary of the honourable, discreet, reputable man. Recent historical summaries describe Freemasonry as rooted in Enlightenment ideals of the *honnête homme* and Christian morality, while scholarship also stresses its role as a secular-style voluntary association on a large scale. That combination matters: early Masonry tried to cultivate civility, morality, fraternity, and public trust without reducing itself to a church or party. In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, especially in Anglo-American Masonic culture, the phrase increasingly came to connote character-building, mutual aid, philanthropy, and the shaping of reliable middle-class citizenship. Charitable culture became more visible. Public suspicion of secret societies also made it useful for Masons to explain themselves not as political conspirators but as moral men dedicated to charity, loyalty, and law. Britannica’s current summary still reflects that older self-description: morality, charity, and

obedience to the law are central to Masonic teaching. In the contemporary UGLE world, the meaning is expressed in the language of core values, onboarding, retention, community engagement, mentoring, and member development. UGLE's Members' Pathway and seven-year strategy use modern organisational language: plan, attract, engage, retrieve; thriving membership, coherent organisation, community engagement; openness; and a "yes, if" attitude. This is a major development. The old maxim survives, but it is now operationalised through management systems, training resources, webinars, communications strategy, digital outreach, and structured member experience. That is not a betrayal of the ideal. It is how a twenty-first-century organisation tries to preserve a centuries-old ethos. So yes, the meaning has developed. But not by replacing the old aspiration with something alien. Rather, Freemasonry has translated the old aspiration into the idiom of each age: from moral respectability, to bourgeois character, to values-led personal growth and social contribution.

What does each word mean?

The strength of the maxim lies in its compression. Each word carries a burden.

"Make" implies process, discipline, and mediation. Nobody simply wakes up better. Betterment is formed through practices, habits, correction, imitation, self-examination, and repeated effort. The word also suggests craft. Freemasonry's symbolic world is built around tools, labour, measure, and shaping rough material into fit material. To "make" a man better is not to flatter him but to work on him—and to have him work on himself. UGLE's description of degree ceremonies as staged moral instruction and its use of building analogies fit this exactly.

"Good" is the hardest word, because it is both morally serious and deliberately incomplete. It does not mean perfect. It means there is already something sound to work with: basic honesty, decency, self-command, and public trustworthiness. Historically, Masonic constitutions express this through "good and true," "good report," maturity, and sound judgment. Modern UGLE language softens the older idiom but still assumes that candidates should be fit for membership and capable of living by the fraternity's values. "Men" reflects both the historical structure of UGLE Craft Masonry and the broader long history of Masonry as a male fraternal form. UGLE remains male-only in Craft membership while publicly acknowledging women's Grand Lodges as separate bodies; at the same time it states membership is open to men over 18 from all backgrounds. Whether one judges the single-sex structure positively or negatively, the word is not incidental. The tradition argues that moral formation is mediated through a specifically fraternal setting. "Better" implies no finish line. It is

comparative, not absolute. That matters enormously. Freemasonry does not claim to make saints or perfect moral beings. Its internal logic is iterative: a man learns, advances, reflects, serves, and tries again. UGLE's own public explanation of the degrees presents them as progressive lessons in equality, self-improvement, and wise use of life. That is betterment not as arrival but as ascent.

How does Freemasonry actually try to make good men better?

This is the central practical question. The phrase has value only if it corresponds to practical means rather than mere sentiment. Broadly speaking, Freemasonry tries to produce betterment through selection, ritual, symbol, fellowship, office, expectation, charity, and repetition.

1. Selection

Freemasonry begins with a filtering principle. Historically the candidate had to be of good report; in UGLE's current framework he must be an adult male and believe in a Supreme Being, while the broader culture of selection still includes reputation, suitability, and fit. The organisation is not designed to begin with men who reject moral obligation itself. That is not sufficient for improvement, but it is the starting condition.

2. Ritual and degree progression

UGLE openly states that there are three degree ceremonies and that they teach members how to be better people, with each degree representing a stage of life. The Entered Apprentice is taught moral equality and duty toward the less fortunate; the Fellow Craft stresses self-improvement; the Master Mason emphasises mortality and using life wisely. This is the most explicit official answer available to your question. Betterment is taught through enacted moral drama, not just lectures.

3. Symbol and allegory

Freemasonry teaches through symbols drawn from building. UGLE says it uses building analogies to teach productive lives that benefit communities. Symbol has a special pedagogical role because it resists shallow consumption: a symbol must be revisited. It trains the member to reflect, not just memorise. That can be powerful because repeated symbolic reflection often reaches areas of character that rule books cannot.

4. Fellowship and example

No moral system works without community. UGLE repeatedly stresses friendship, harmony, and shared values. Members dine together, work together, volunteer

together, and often speak of being surrounded by men with similar ethics who encourage one another upward. That social environment is crucial. Men improve when they are ashamed to disappoint honourable peers and inspired to imitate admirable ones.

5. Office and responsibility

The older constitutions tie advancement to merit. In practice, fraternal office trains punctuality, reliability, public speaking, memory, organisation, and service. A man becomes “better” partly because people begin to depend on him. Responsibility is one of the oldest moral schools in the world.

6. Charity and service

The modern public identity of most Grand Lodges strongly links Masonry to community engagement, volunteering, and charity. Service matters because it takes moral language out of abstraction. A man becomes better not when he says noble things but when he gives time, money, labour, and attention to the vulnerable.

7. Repetition over time

Freemasonry is not a motivational event. Its structure assumes repeated attendance, gradual advancement, long memory, and lifelong practice. UGLE’s public materials and strategy work on retention, engagement, and pathways because the organisation knows that transformation requires duration. The maxim only works when lived as a habit.

Is choosing “good men” elitism or necessity?

It can be either, depending on how the phrase is interpreted and practiced. It becomes elitism when “good” is treated as a flattering synonym for wealth, class, profession, pedigree, or social polish. Historically, Masonic culture has sometimes been vulnerable to that temptation, because “good report” can be captured by prevailing class codes. If a lodge mistakes status for virtue, then the phrase degenerates into self-congratulation. A fraternity of the comfortable calling itself morally select is not automatically noble. That danger is real. Historical exclusions in the old texts remind us that the tradition arose inside non-egalitarian societies. But in a more defensible sense, choosing “good men” is a necessity of method. Any institution of trust, oath, mutual formation, and reputation must screen for baseline moral seriousness. Schools choose students with basic preparedness; monasteries choose novices with basic vocation; professions choose entrants with basic competence. Freemasonry, by its own logic, is not meant to create moral consciousness from nothing. It is meant to refine it. In that

sense the phrase does not say, “We are better than everyone else.” It says, “This method presupposes something to work on.”

The practical answer, then, is this: the phrase is not necessarily elitist, but it becomes elitist whenever status substitutes for character. A serious lodge should guard against that relentlessly. The point is not to recruit prestigious men. The point is to recruit men who are teachable, honourable, and capable of improvement. UGLE’s public effort to stress openness across backgrounds rather than exclusivity is clearly aimed at avoiding the old trap.

How do we judge whether someone is a “good man”?

No organisation can read souls. It can only make provisional judgments based on evidence. Historically that evidence was “good report,” maturity, and discretion. Modern equivalents are more practical. A good candidate is not a perfect man but a man whose life shows enough moral stability that the fraternity can responsibly trust him. Reasonable criteria would include honesty in dealing, willingness to keep commitments, absence of scandalous conduct, respect for law, capacity to coexist with difference, a pattern of taking responsibility for family and work, and an actual desire for self-improvement. UGLE’s guidance materials stress obedience to the law, loyalty, rejection of political agitation inside the lodge, and basic religious seriousness through belief in a Supreme Being. Its public values add integrity, respect, friendship, and service. Together those make a practical moral profile.

The crucial test is not whether a man is admired, successful, or polished. It is whether he is trustworthy and corrigible. “Trustworthy” means others can rely on him. “Corrigible” means he can still learn. A man who is already self-satisfied may be less fit for Masonic growth than a humbler man with evident flaws but real openness to discipline. That conclusion is partly an inference from the Masonic model of progressive instruction and improvement, but it matches the spirit of the sources.

What are the formal criteria for acceptance?

Under UGLE, the publicly stated baseline is that membership is open to men aged over 18, irrespective of race or religion, and UGLE guidance states that the first condition of admission and membership is belief in a Supreme Being. The older constitutional tradition also speaks of “good and true men,” mature and discreet age, sound judgment, and good report. Those formal and quasi-formal requirements show a mixture of contemporary openness and inherited landmarks. Beyond those basics,

actual admission also depends on lodge-level processes of acquaintance, recommendation, and ballot. Even where public pages simplify the join process, the internal culture is clearly not “anyone who fills in a form is automatically fit.” UGLE’s current membership strategy and pathway work assume that attraction must be followed by engagement, mentoring, and retention. That implies discernment at entry and support afterward. It is important to add a hard truth: no admission system perfectly predicts later conduct. Any fraternity that claims otherwise is lying to itself. A candidate may look promising and later disappoint. The real test of the maxim is not whether Masonry never admits weak men, but whether it has the courage to teach, correct, and if necessary discipline members whose conduct fails the ideal. UGLE’s data-protection and disciplinary references show that records relating to disciplinary matters and conduct bringing Freemasonry into disrepute do exist as part of governance.

Is becoming better a continuous effort, and how long does it take?

Yes. And it takes as long as the man is alive. The grammar of “better” already gives that away. Better compared to what? Better than yesterday, better than one’s own earlier habits, better than one’s uncorrected impulses, better at service, better at judgment, better at friendship, better at ruling oneself. It is a comparative without endpoint. UGLE’s staged description of the degrees already implies ongoing development, and its present strategic language around member pathways, learning, onboarding, and engagement assumes that formation continues after initiation. This matters philosophically. If the phrase were taken to mean that Masonry can finish a man in three ceremonies, it would be absurd. Ritual opens a road; it does not complete it. The more realistic interpretation is that Freemasonry provides a lifetime framework for self-correction. A man may improve in one phase through mastering ego, in another through family duty, in another through charity, and in another through preparing younger members. The craft becomes a pattern of life, not a short course.

Who can judge whether a member really became better?

No single judge is sufficient. The member himself must judge first, because conscience cannot be outsourced. Freemasonry’s symbolic and reflective character presupposes personal examination. A man who never asks whether he is more honest, patient, charitable, and useful has missed the point. That is the inward court. His brethren judge second, not in the sense of self-righteous surveillance but in the sense of lived evidence. Does he keep his word? Does he serve? Does he grow easier to trust?

Does he respond well to responsibility? That is the fraternal court. UGLE's emphasis on harmony, friendship, mentoring, and engagement makes little sense unless brethren are expected to observe and support one another's growth. Society judges third. This is often forgotten, but it may be the hardest test. If a Mason is no better husband, father, colleague, neighbour, citizen, or volunteer than before, then the phrase has failed in public terms. UGLE's own public presentation explicitly ties Masonic values to private and public life and to positive contribution in communities. That makes external fruits relevant, not irrelevant. The fairest answer is therefore: the man knows inwardly, the lodge sees relationally, and the world sees externally. If all three registers agree, then the betterment is credible.

How is the maxim implemented in practice today?

Modern implementation is much more structured than many outsiders assume. UGLE's recent strategy materials show that contemporary Masonry does not rely only on tradition repeating itself. It uses explicit organisational tools to attract, welcome, educate, integrate, and retain members. The Members' Pathway is especially important here. UGLE materials describe it through four areas—Plan, Attract, Engage, Retrieve—and connect it directly to the wider strategy. That is effectively the organisation's operational answer to how values become lived culture. Implementation works on several levels. There is recruitment language that emphasises values and betterment rather than secrecy or privilege. There are onboarding and educational resources, including online learning through Solomon and webinar series reflecting on the meaning of degrees. There are local membership and mentoring officers in some provinces. There are communications campaigns designed to align local lodges with national values. And there is explicit pressure from leadership to adopt these systems consistently if Freemasonry is to thrive. This is important because slogans die when institutions fail to build habits underneath them. UGLE's present strategic work suggests it understands that preserving the maxim requires formation architecture: not only grand words, but repeatable processes.

How should quality and ethos be taught to Freemasons?

If the goal is truly to take good men from society and help them become better, then quality and ethos must be taught in ways that match how adults actually change. Preaching alone is not enough. At least six things are needed. First, clarity of purpose. Every initiate should hear early and often that Freemasonry is not chiefly about regalia, status, nostalgia, or social vanity, but about character, brotherhood, and service.

UGLE's contemporary values framework is useful here because it gives a plain vocabulary for what the fraternity expects. Second, mentored interpretation of ritual. Ritual without guidance becomes pageantry. Ritual with guided reflection becomes moral education. UGLE's public learning resources and Second Degree onboarding model point in the right direction: members should be helped to ask what a degree means for work, home, conduct, and duty. Third, example from respected members. Men imitate what gets honoured. If lodges reward only ritual performance, seniority, or dining culture, they will get superficial members. If they honour reliability, humility, service, mentoring, and integrity, they will form better ones. The old constitutions' insistence on merit rather than mere seniority remains a healthy corrective. Fourth, real opportunities for service. Ethos becomes real when members must do something concrete for others. UGLE's extensive emphasis on charity and community engagement is not just public relations. It is one of the main ways character is exercised. Fifth, fraternal correction with kindness. A lodge that never corrects laziness, vanity, factionalism, or bad conduct cannot make men better. Brotherhood is not indulgence. It is patient accountability. Sixth, continuity across the whole Masonic journey. Betterment should not be treated as a beginner's theme and then forgotten. It should recur in every office, every lecture, every charitable action, and every act of lodge culture. UGLE's stress on engagement and retention implicitly recognises this.

What are the dangers hidden inside the maxim?

A strong essay should not romanticize the phrase. It has dangers. One danger is complacent self-congratulation. Men can say "we make good men better" and quietly mean "we are already superior." That destroys the humility without which no betterment is possible. A second danger is vagueness. If "better" is never specified, it becomes empty branding. UGLE avoids some of that emptiness by naming concrete values—Integrity, Friendship, Respect, and Service—and tying them to actual member life. A third danger is performative morality. A member may become good at ritual or lodge prestige while remaining selfish or petty in daily life. That is why society's judgment matters. A fourth danger is status capture. As noted earlier, lodges can mistake social polish, education, business success, or influence for goodness. The phrase then becomes a screen for class vanity rather than a school of moral labour. A fifth danger is institutional drift. Any old institution can retain a maxim long after forgetting the practices that made it credible. That is why modern strategy, mentoring, and learning systems matter.

Does the maxim still have value in today's society?

Yes, but only if taken seriously. Today's society is fast, distracted, transactional, and often morally thin. Many institutions train competence but do little to train character. Many social networks connect people but do not bind them to duty. Many men are information-rich and formation-poor. In that environment, a durable fraternity that asks members to reflect on integrity, respect, friendship, service, mortality, and responsibility may offer something genuinely needed. UGLE explicitly presents its values as still ringing true in today's uncertain world. The maxim also speaks to a civic need. Scholarship on Freemasonry's historical role in civil society is relevant here. Voluntary associations help teach cooperation, trust, and public-mindedness outside the state. Where those habits weaken, democratic and communal life weakens too. If Freemasonry still helps men practice reliability, charity, respectful disagreement, and shared labour, then the maxim remains socially significant, not just privately comforting. But its value today is conditional. Its value depends on whether the fraternity can prove in lived form that it produces men more capable of service, steadiness, and moral seriousness. In a world skeptical of institutions, slogans no longer receive automatic respect. They must be demonstrated. UGLE's modern push toward transparency, community engagement, and clearer public explanation suggests it knows this.

A final judgement

"Make good men better" endures because it expresses, in a single line, the best self-understanding of Freemasonry: not that it creates human worth from nothing, not that it grants superiority, and not that it substitutes for religion, law, family, or citizenship, but that it offers a disciplined brotherhood of moral improvement. Historically, the phrase should not be treated too literally as a single unaltered official motto documented for three hundred years under that exact wording. The older English constitutional language spoke of "good and true men," "good report," and "real worth and personal merit." Modern UGLE speaks the language of values, openness, character, and community engagement. But the thread connecting those worlds is real. The maxim is powerful because it names a human truth: goodness is not enough if it remains unworked. Raw decency must be refined into character. Character must be tested in fellowship. Fellowship must bear fruit in service. Service must be sustained across a lifetime. On that reading, Freemasonry does not claim to possess moral perfection; it claims to provide a workshop where moral life can be practiced with seriousness, symbol, accountability, and fraternity. That is why the phrase survived. It survived

because generations of Masons found that it was broad enough to invite them in, demanding enough to challenge them, and humble enough to keep them unfinished. And that is the real meaning of the maxim. It is not that Masonry declares certain men already superior. It is that it calls men to accept that being decent is only the beginning. To be good is the admission ticket. To become better is the work. And to keep becoming better until the end of life is the craft itself.

Thank you, Brethren.

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